haute monde, those like Deepika Padukone, Disha Patani, Rashmika Mandanna, or local pop meisters like A.R. Rahman, Diljit Dosanjh and Badshah.

BITTEN BY THE KOREA BUG

The Korean Wave washing up here is no pop-ecological accident. In her 2014 book *The Birth of Korean Cool*, American-born, Paris-based Korean journalist Euny Hong explains how Seoul has made becoming the world's top exporter of popular culture its top priority. "The nation has decided that the 21st century will be Korea's century, just as the 20th century was America's century," she writes. "And it's not enough for Korea to make semiconductors and cars; it has to be cool as well."

That said, Indians have long been familiar with Korean brands like Samsung, LG, Hyundai and Kia. A Korean expat community of around 17,000 is spread across Sriperumbudur near Chennai, Delhi-NCR—home to several Korean companies—and Pune's Kharadi, Viman Nagar, Baner and Balewadi areas. Bilateral trade between India and Korea was $27.52 billion (Rs 2.36 lakh crore) in FY24 and is expected to soar to $50 billion (Rs 4.3 lakh crore) by 2030.

Alongside, South Korea is leveraging its soft power, using communication, visual content and music to promote the Korean way of life worldwide. While *Parasite* became the first international film to win the Best Picture Oscar in 2019, BTS contributed more than $4.65 billion to South Korea's

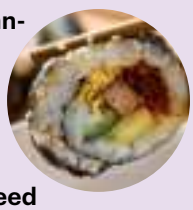
FOOD DELIVERY PLATFORM SWIGGY HAS SEEN 59 PER CENT GROWTH IN ORDERS FOR KOREAN FOOD IN THE PAST THREE YEARS



K-FOOD
A NEW STAPLE

Delicious Korean dishes ranging from rice preparations to spicy noodles delight Indian palataes. A few of the most popular orders

KIMBAP: A Korean-style sushi roll made with rice, vegetables, egg and sometimes meat or fish, all wrapped in seaweed



BIBIMBAP: A rice bowl topped with sautéed vegetables, gochujang, fried egg and meat. You have to mix everything before eating



TTEOKBOKKI: A popular street food in Korea, these are chewy rice cakes cooked in a spicy-sweet *gochujang* sauce

GOCHUJANG: A fermented Korean chilli paste made from glutinous rice, fermented soybeans, red chilli etc.

RAMYEON: Instant Korean soup noodles, usually spicy, served with toppings like egg, scallions or cheese

